

# Homily on the Ten Virgins (De decem virginibus)

English translation by Luke J. Stevens, 2020

## Translation

<sup>1</sup> It is worthwhile also for this figure of the ten virgins to be interpreted, which is in this way:

<sup>2</sup> *Then the kingdom of heaven will be like ten virgins, who taking their lamps went out to meet the bridegroom and the bride; five of them were foolish, and five wise; the foolish having taken their lamps did not take with them <oil in their vessels; the wise, though, took> oil in their vessels with the lamps. But as the bridegroom tarried, they all fell asleep. But in the middle of the night a cry arose: "Behold, the bridegroom comes, go forth to meet him!" Then those ten virgins arose and trimmed their lamps. And the foolish ones said to the wise: "Give us of your oil, for our lamps have gone out." And the wise answered: "Lest there be not enough for us and you, go rather to the sellers, and buy for yourselves." While they went to buy, the bridegroom came, and those who were ready entered with him into the wedding banquet, and the door was shut. Later came the rest of the virgins, saying: "Lord, open to us." He answered: "Amen, I say to you, I do not know you." Keep watch, therefore, since you know neither the day nor the hour.*

[Matt 25:1–13](#)

<sup>3</sup> Some say that those virgins are two peoples, wrongly of course: for the synagogues are not virgins; for they have the man Moses. Some say that those virgins are the heretical sects, falsely of course: for the heretical sects are not virgins; they are adulteresses. For virgins of God's house are of serene face, chaste expression, modest appearance, restrained eyes, pleasant words, sweet prayer, gentle disposition. Such is Christ, such the image. Yet all the heretical sects are of sad face, impudent expression, wicked eyes, harsh words, wicked prayer, savage disposition, obstinate contention of lies, and full of bitterness of all error, stuffed with curses and scorns. Therefore, since the heretical sects are unlikely, the synagogues are unlikely, the Decalogue, which certain ones bring in, is unlikely, we will discuss about the virgins themselves.

<sup>4</sup> The wise virgins are the churches, indeed—as I say more truly—this part of the people that keeps the law of God, loves piety, forgives attacks, prays for its enemies, offers itself as generous to the widow and orphan, delightful to the guest, humane to the foreigner, attentive to the needy, enters prisons, approaches mines, forced laborers, exiles, rescues the imperiled, visits the sick, satisfies the hungry with bread, refreshes the thirsty with drink, consoles the downcast, raises the prostrate, strengthens the terrified, softens the cruel, makes the severe mild, alleviates the harsh, humbles the arrogant, bravely endures suffering, patiently

bears hunger, thirst, cold, endures condemnations, sorrows, exiles, mines, prisons, with calm mind. This is the righteousness of the wise virgins owed to God, this price of eternal life, this garland of the Church. This is that image of the kingdom of the immortal Christ. This is that distinct crown with the precious stone, perfused with starry redness.

<sup>5</sup> But that part of the people, to whom the name of the foolish virgins is ascribed, since, with neglect of God, neglect of their brothers, arrogance, hatred toward the poor, toward the orphan, the foreigner, offer themselves away from all the virtues that I recalled above, they will be found without a share in that kingdom of Christ. For this is that part of the people that on the day of judgment stands at the left hand, the same that the Evangelist distinguishes <by the name> of young goats; but he calls what stands at the right hand lambs.

[Matt 25:32–33](#)

<sup>6</sup> It is therefore clear that these ten virgins are <like> the Christian people, whose foolish part and wise part, of five virgins each, is described. The vessels are bodies; the lamps and their light, souls; the oil, good works or prayer and God's mercy; the bridegroom, Christ; the bride, the Church. The closed door is the fiery river by which the impious are separated from the kingdom of God, as it is written in Daniel and in Peter—in his Apocalypse.

[Dan 7:10; Apoc Pet 6:2](#)

<sup>7</sup> We read thus: When the bridegroom begins to tarry, the wise virgins will devote themselves to prayer and await the kingdom of God. However, when certain signs of God's coming begin to appear from heaven, the foolish virgins will ask those wise ones to petition for their sins. Then they will answer them: "Since we too have sins, we fear that our prayer is not strong enough to obtain for both you and us; go rather and buy for yourselves from those who sell."

<sup>8</sup> Who, you ask, are those who sell that oil of mercy? Receive: the blind, the lame, the thirsty, the crippled, the poor, the widows, the orphans, the foreigners, the exiles, those condemned to the mines, the prisoners, the sick, and the rest like these. Therefore, these wretched ones who are late to consider their own health die before obtaining absolution for their sins, and on the day of judgment they find the door shut. For thus it says: *But as the bridegroom tarried, they all fell asleep*—that is, they died.

<sup>9</sup> Therefore, on the day of judgment, as I have said, when the trumpet blows and the shout is made, all the righteous will rise and enter with Christ in his kingdom. That foolish part will rise too, and it will find the door already shut—opposite, of course, the fiery river—and will ask him to open that door. He will answer: "Amen, I say to you, I do not know you."

[1 Thess 4:16](#)

<sup>10</sup> For all examination it seems worthy to explain why Zechariah did not believe the angel Gabriel evangelizing about John the Baptist, his own future son, and became mute.

[Luke 1:18–20](#)

## Notes

The Latin text, from a single eighth-century manuscript, was first edited by Delisle,<sup>1</sup> then republished with minor editorial emendations by Wilmart,<sup>2</sup> whose text has been reprinted in PLS 1:172–74. The present translation follows the latter, with the further addition of paragraph numbers to facilitate reference.

The Biblical text is Old Latin, though not quite like any parallel specimen. As Wilmart observes, the nature of the text is not a homily, as the manuscript claims, but an excerpt from a commentary on the Gospels, with the text's final paragraph taken from the following section (the seventh-century *Expositiunculæ* likewise proceeds from the same passage of Matthew to the same passage of Luke.)

Wilmart suggests authorship by Victorinus of Poetovio. Dulaey acknowledges the likelihood of its connection to Victorinus but sees a subsequent homilist drawing from Victorinus's *Commentary on the Gospels* as more plausible.<sup>3</sup> Undoubtedly echoing the latter, both Fortunatian, *Comm. ev. M.* 106, and Hilary, *Tract. Matt.* 27, provide close parallels, yet without altogether identical exegesis. The present text is perhaps among Jerome's sources in his *Comm. Matt.* 25.1–13.<sup>4</sup>

This text has been of interest to scholars primarily for two features. First, its repeated references to mines (*metalla*) among prisons, forced labor, and exile witness to the practice of punishment by condemnation to the mines and its Latin terminology. Second, and far more famously, the text offers one of the few explicit citations of the Apocalypse of Peter—in Latin, still more remarkably<sup>5</sup>—referring to the river of fire therein;<sup>6</sup> rather than direct knowledge of this work, the homilist more likely takes up the reference at second (or even third) hand, presumably by way of Victorinus.<sup>7</sup>

Revised 8 Apr 2023

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<sup>1</sup> Léopold Delisle, *Notice sur un manuscrit mérovingien de la bibliothèque d'Epinal* (Paris: Champion, 1878), 15–17. Available [online](#).

<sup>2</sup> André Wilmart, "Un anonyme ancien de *x virginibus*," *BALAC* 1 (1911): 35–49, 88–102. Available [online](#).

<sup>3</sup> Martine Dulaey, *Victorin de Poetovio, premier exégète latin*, Collection des Études augustiniennes, Série Antiquité 139–140 (Paris: Études augustiniennes, 1993), 39–42, 319–20. Nikolay A. Khandoga, "Is Saint Victorinus of Poetovio the Author of the Homily 'On the Ten Virgins'?" *Issues of Theology* 3 (2021): 5–23 (in Russian, available [online](#)), concurs on other grounds.

<sup>4</sup> Dulaey, *Victorin*, 337–38.

<sup>5</sup> It is listed in the Muratorian Fragment and in the canon list in Codex Claromontanus. Two other Latin texts, both from roughly Victorinus's time, are suspected of drawing without attribution from the Apocalypse of Peter: Pseudo-Cyprian, *De laude martyrii* 19–21 and *Adversos aleatores* 8. See Dennis D. Buchholz, *Your Eyes Will Be Opened: A Study of the Greek (Ethiopic) Apocalypse of Peter*, SBLDS 97 (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1988), 20–80.

<sup>6</sup> Thus listed in GCS NF 11:96.

<sup>7</sup> Also responsible for the Muratorian Fragment's mention of the Apocalypse of Peter, according to Jonathan J. Armstrong, "Victorinus of Pettau as the Author of the Canon Muratori," *VC* 62 (2008): 1–34.